

Marx, ideology and culture

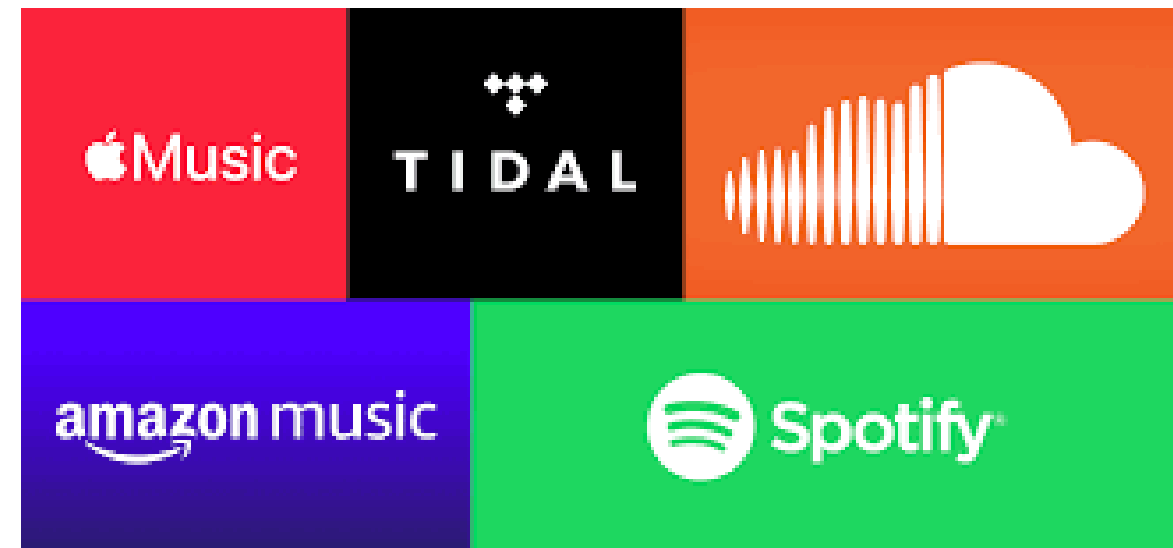
- Marx was a journalist in his early life and it was a source of income for him
- However, **Marx did not write explicitly about 'culture'** although there are **references to culture in his texts**
- There are **differing, but related**, varieties of ideology in Marx
- **Early Marx** – German ideology (ruling class ideas, means of mental production), camera obscura), Contribution to Critique (Base / superstructure), **Late Marx**, Capital (Critique of political economy, commodification).

Marx - The German Ideology (1846)

Ruling class ideas and the 'means of mental production'

The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas, i.e. the class which is the ruling material force of society, is at the same time its ruling intellectual force. The class which has the means of production at its disposal, has control at the same time over the **means of mental production**, so that thereby, generally speaking, the **ideas of those who lack the means of mental production are subject to it.**

The German Ideology (1845)



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Madonna 'Material Girl' (1984)

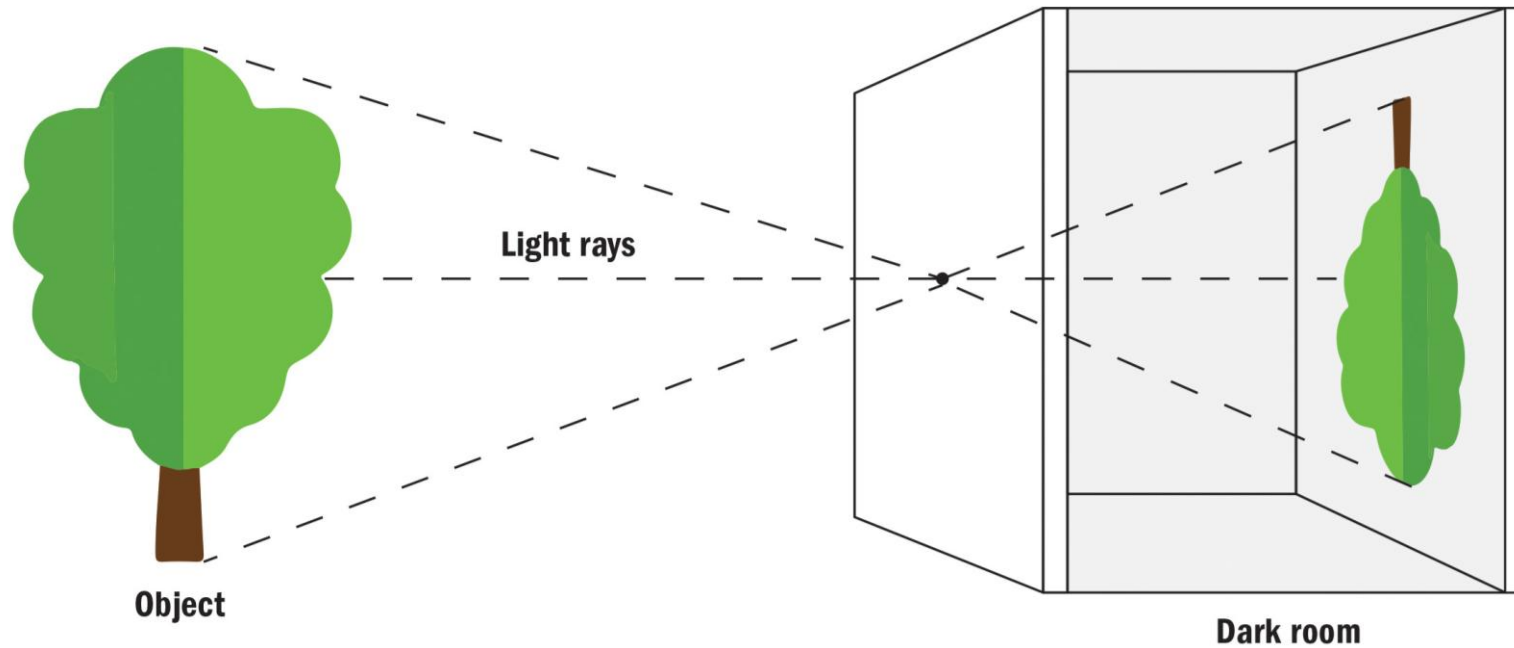
Some boys kiss me, some boys hug me
I think they're okay
If they don't give me proper credit
I just walk away

They can beg and they can plead
But they can't see the light (that's right)
'Cause the boy with the cold hard cash
Is always Mister Right

'Cause we are living in a material world
And I am a material girl
You know that we are living in a material
world
And I am a material gir



Bridegroom, dear
to my heart,
Goodly is your
beauty,
honeysweet,
Lion, dear to my
heart,
Goodly is your
beauty...
(First ever Love
Poem -*The Love
Song of Shu-Sin*,
2000 BC)



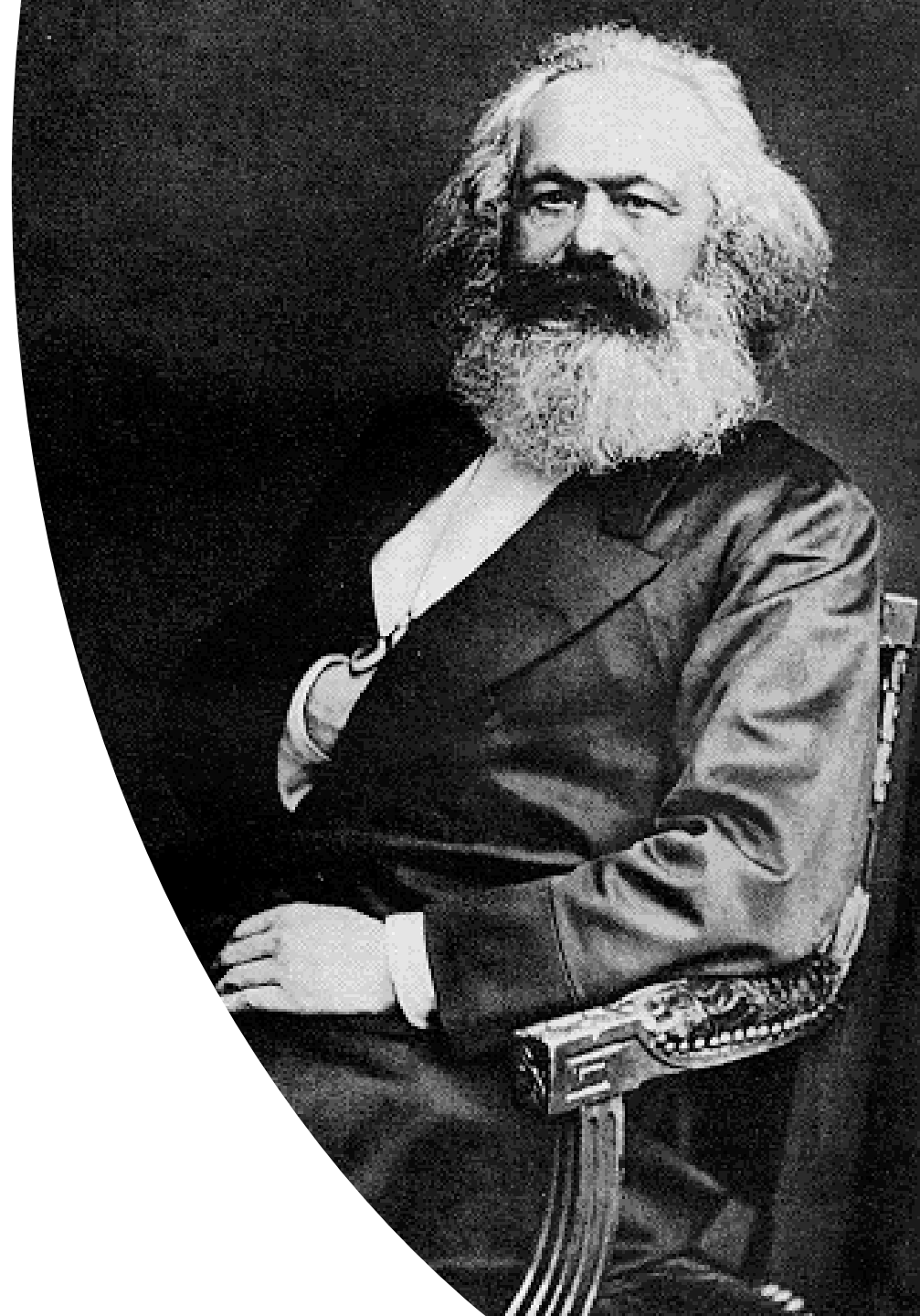
Ideology represents class relations in an illusory form in so far as these ideas **do not accurately portray the nature and relative positions of the classes concerned**; rather, ideology misrepresent these relations in a way which **concurs with the interests of the dominant class**.

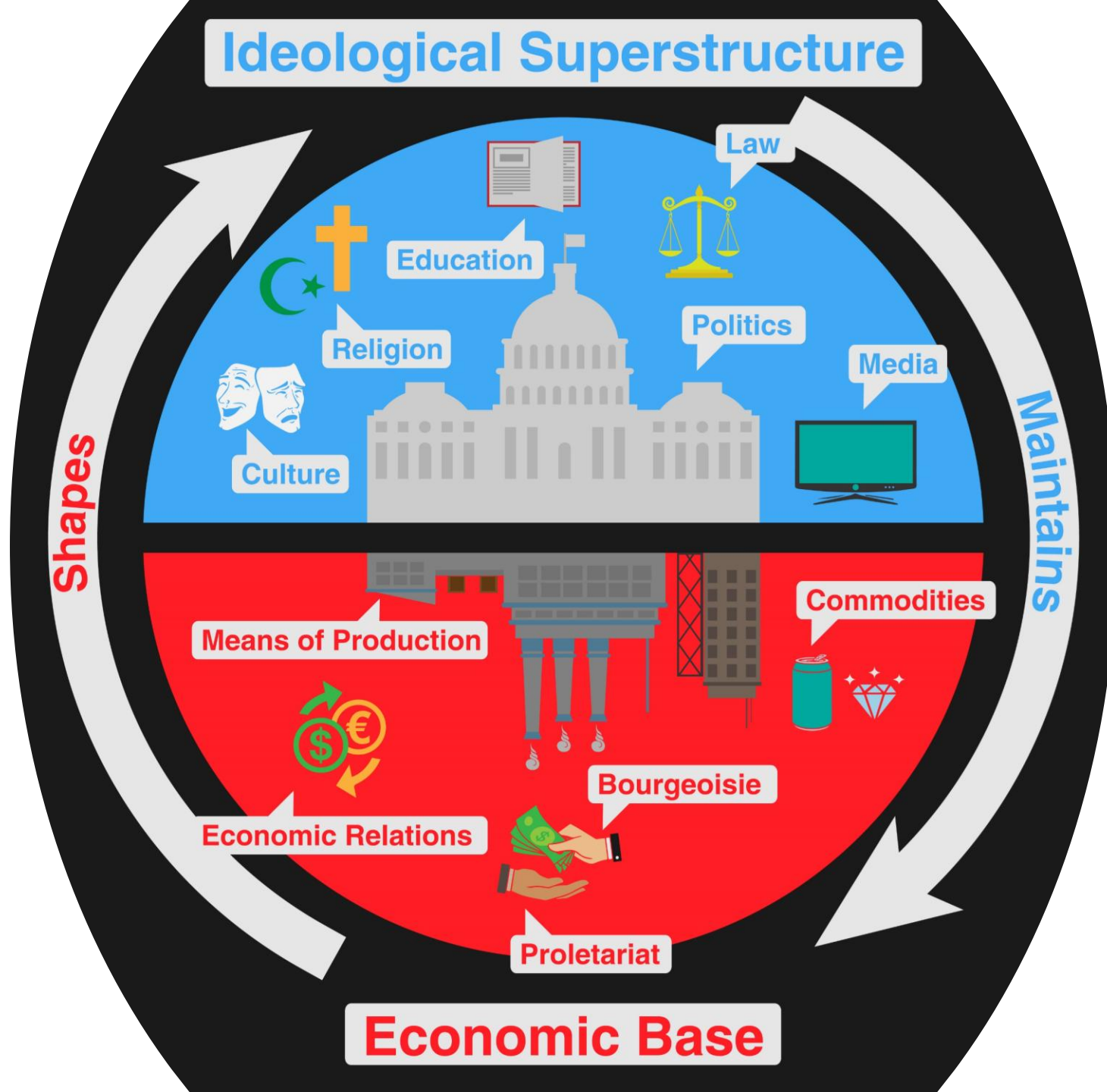
Marx – Contribution to a Critique of Political Economy (1859)

Base and Superstructure

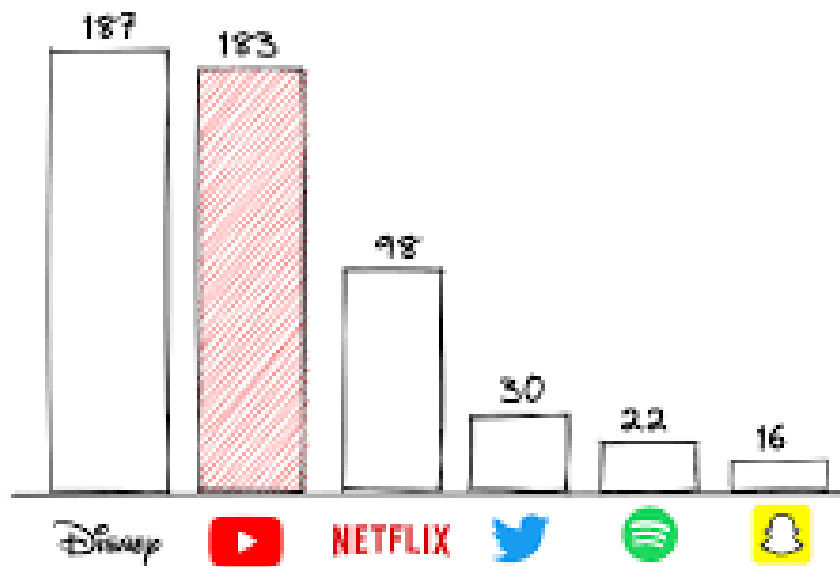
“In the social production of their existence, men enter into definite, necessary relations, which are independent of their will, namely, relations of reproduction corresponding to a definite stage of development of their material forces of production. The totality of these relations of production constitutes the economic structure of society, **the real foundation on which there arises a legal and political superstructure** and to which there correspond **definite forms of social consciousness**”.

*Preface and Introduction to a Contribution to
the Critique of Political Economy (1859)*





YouTube Valuation vs Listed Peers (\$USbn)



Source: YouTube DCF valuation vs peer market cap 2022

www.khowie.com



25 biggest music artists on YouTube 2025

Marx – Capital: A Critique of Political Economy (Three volumes) (1867, 1885, 1894)

Musicians as wage labourers

“A singer who sings like a bird is an unproductive worker. If she sells her song for money, she is to that extent a wage-labourer or merchant. But if the same singer is engaged by an entrepreneur who makes her sing to make money, then she becomes a productive worker, since she produces capital directly” (Marx, Capital Volume 1)



Materialist ideology

Materialism

- Musicians hold labour power
- Labour power in exchange for a wage (reproduction)
- Produce a commodity (music)
- $M - C - C' - M'$ (circulation)
- Capitalist invests in fixed capital (studios / production / distribution)

Ideology

- Record companies make 'stars'
- You can be a star by being a musician and make lots of money
- Music is special
- Music is precious
- Music is an industry, technological progress is good for the music industry

Music as working-class emancipation?

Materialist oppression and emancipation

Commodification

Independent, radical, even anti-capitalist music can be sold as a commodity by capitalists.



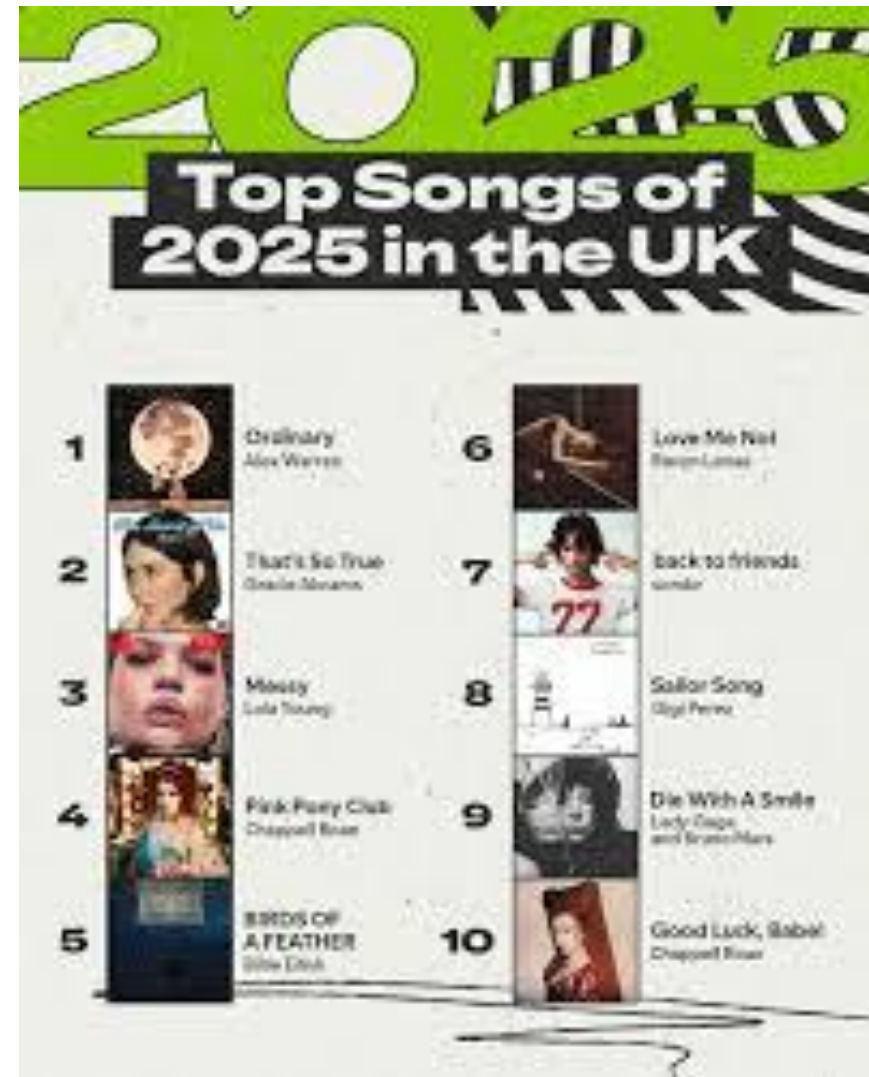
‘Between equal rights, force decides’
(Capital, Volume 1) and ‘The history of all
hitherto existing societies is the history of
class struggle’ (Communist Manifesto)

BUT – Capitalism creates own gravediggers /
Capitalist crisis / Worker organisation



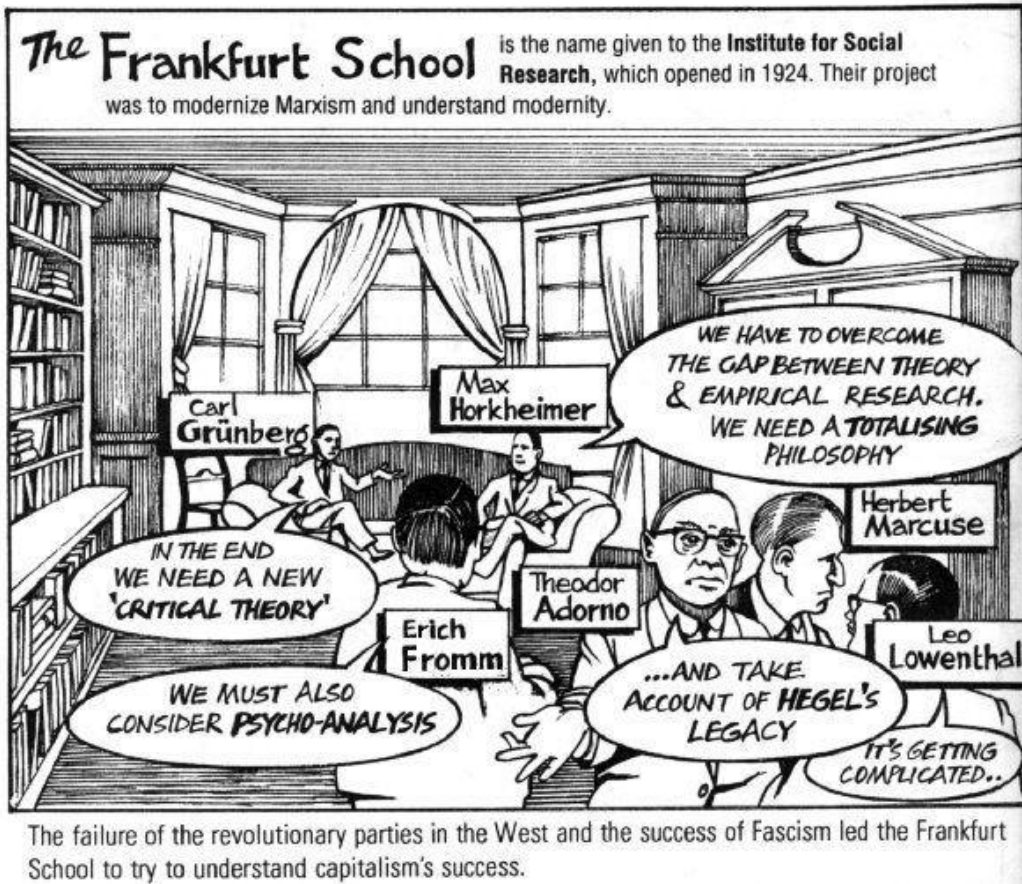
MARX AND COMMODITY FETISHISM

“The relation of the producers to the sum total of their own labour is **presented to them as a social relation of objects** which exists outside them... It is a particular social relation between men themselves which in their eyes assumes a **phantasmagorical form of a relation between things**...This is what I call **fetishism**; it attaches itself to the products of labour as soon as they are produced as **commodities**, and it is therefore inseparable from the production of commodities”. *Capital* (1867)



Adorno and Horkheimer – Dialectic of Enlightenment (1947)

The Frankfurt School: Felix Weil (1898-1975), Max Horkheimer (1895-1973), Theodor Adorno (1903-1969), Walter Benjamin (1892-1940),



- ❖ Tradition of thinking commonly known as critical theory, first established around the Institute of Social Research at the University of Frankfurt in 1923.
- ❖ Following Marx they were preoccupied with the forces which moved society towards rational institutions which would ensure an authentic and egalitarian life.
- ❖ Paid more attention to areas considered to be part of the superstructure rather than the economic base.
- ❖ Especially interested in the idea of culture as a new form of ideological control.
COMMODIFICATION + STANDARDISATION + PSEUDO INDIVIDUALISATION

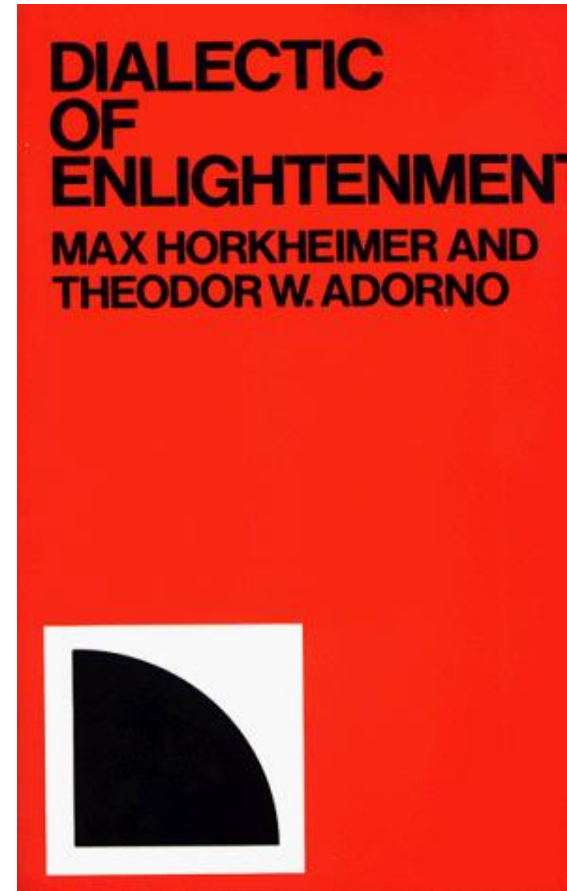
The Culture Industry

“The total effect of the culture industry is one of **anti-enlightenment** ... [it] becomes **mass deception** and is turned into a means for **fettering consciousness**. It **impedes the development of autonomous, independent individuals** who judge and decide consciously for themselves.”

Dialectic of Enlightenment (1947)

(see also Adorno – On Popular Music
(1941)

<https://libcom.org/article/pop-music-theodor-adorno>



Standardisation – mass cultural production, uniformity

Example: Verse / Chorus / Verse / Chorus / Bridge / Chorus

Taylor Swift (2014) 'Shake It Off'

Verse 1

I stay out too late Got nothin' in my brain.
That's what people say, mm-mm...

Chorus

'Cause the players gonna play, play, play,
play, play And the haters gonna hate, hate,
hate, hate, hate Baby, I'm just gonna shake,
shake, shake, shake, shake...

Verse 2

I never miss a beat I'm lightnin' on my feet
And that's what they don't see, mm-mm...

Chorus

Cause the players gonna play, play, play, play,
play. And the haters gonna hate, hate, hate,
hate, hate. Baby, I'm just gonna shake, shake,
shake, shake, shake..

Bridge

My ex-man brought his new girlfriend She's
like, "Oh my God," but I'm just gonna shake
And to the fella over there with the hella good
hair...

Chorus

Cause the players gonna play, play, play, play,
play And the haters gonna hate, hate, hate,
hate, hate (Haters gonna hate Baby, I'm just
gonna shake, shake, shake, shake, shake..



Pseudoindividuality – illusion of choice, disguising standardisation

Example: Charli XCX ‘Von Dutch’



[Verse]

**It's okay to just admit that you're jealous of me
Yeah, I heard you talk about me, that's the word
on the street You're obsessing, just confess it,
put your hands up It's obvious I'm your number
one**

[Pre-Chorus]

**It's alright to just admit that I'm the fantasy
You're obsessing, just confess it 'cause it's
obvious I'm your number one, I'm your number
one I'm your number one, yeah**

[Chorus]

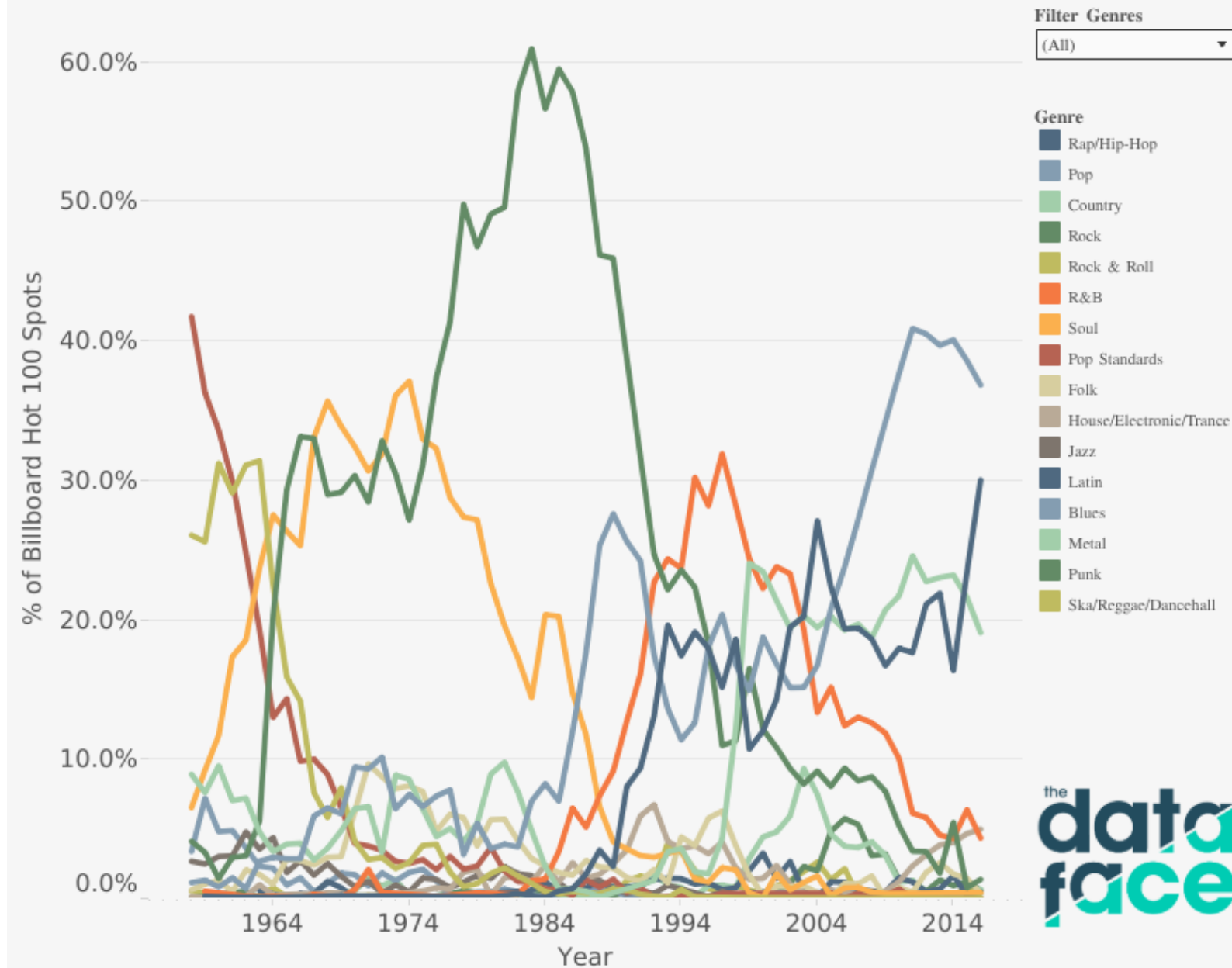
**I'm just living that life Von Dutch, cult classic,
but I still pop get money, you get mad because
the bank's shut Yeah, I know your little secret,
put your hands up t's so obvious I'm your
number one, life Von Dutch, cult classic in your
eardrums**

**-Electroclash style. Blends 1980s
synthpop with contemporary pop**

**-Edgy and alternative in terms of
repeated f-word in chart pop-song,
image as subversive pop star, video
featuring stylised violence**

**- Subverts the conventional pop –
song but reproduces its structure**

Tracing the "Lifecycle" of Each Music Genre in the U.S.



the
data
face

‘Catharsis for the masses..but catharsis that keeps them in line in any case’ (Adorno)

Example: Oasis (1994) ‘Cigarettes and Alcohol’

**Is it my imagination
Or have I finally found something worth living for?
I was looking for some action
But all I found was cigarettes and alcohol**

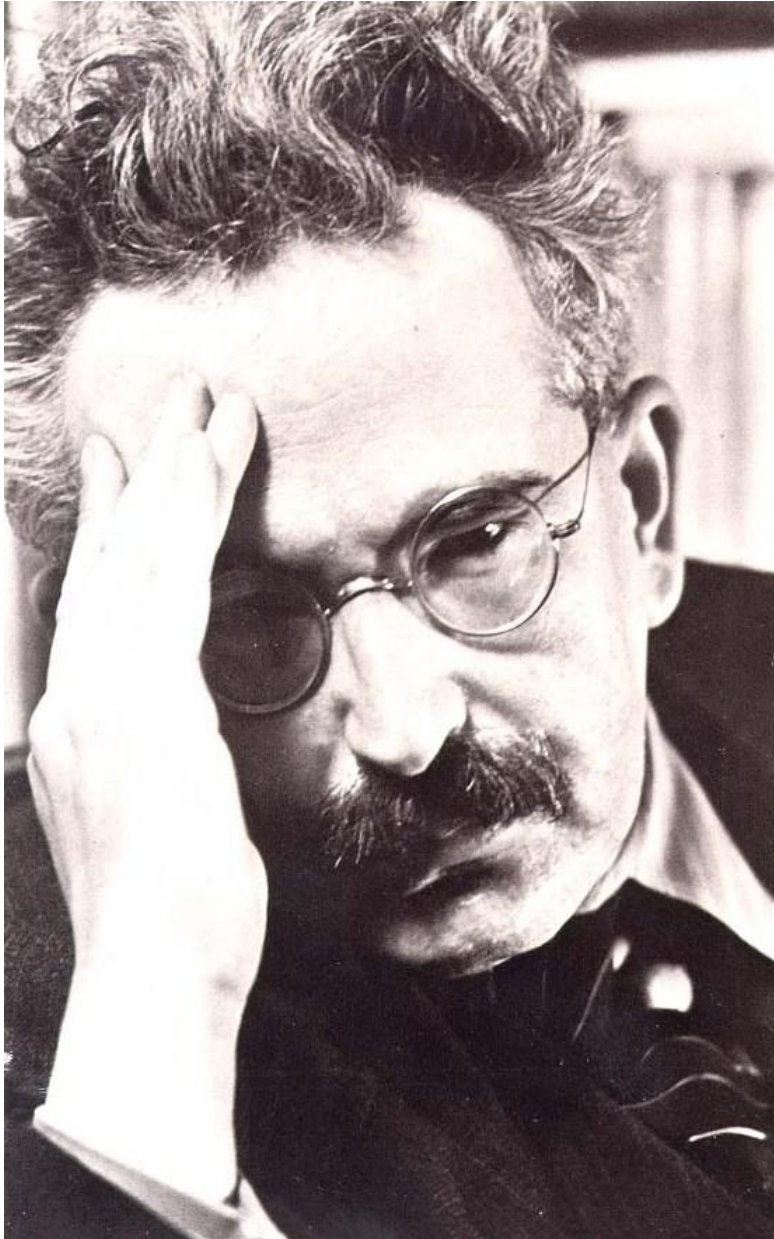
**You could wait for a lifetime
To spend your days in the sunshine
You might as well do the white line
'Cause when it comes on top
You gotta make it happen
You gotta make it happen
You gotta make it happen
You gotta make it happen**

**Is it worth the aggravation
To find yourself a job when there's nothing worth working for?
It's a crazy situation
But all I need are cigarettes and alcohol**



Benjamin - The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction (1935)

Walter Benjamin (1892-1940)

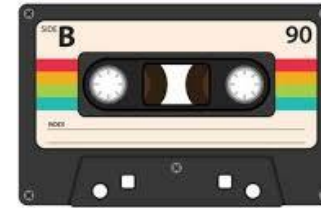


- One of the causes of this apparent decline in cultural authority and enlightenment are media technologies, or what Walter Benjamin referred to as 'an age of mechanical reproduction'.
- Benjamin was optimistic about his own era of technical innovation and the 'debasement' of art from historical ritual and tradition
- Society would be freer to 'organise and control themselves in their reception', i.e. no longer subject to the authority (what he called the aura) of original works of art.

The Subversive Truth of Art

- Decline of authentic art and the system of patronage.
- Aided the promotion of truth and critical-rational experience.
- Gives life to that which is normally suppressed.

“Through art one can conceive a world different from the life dominated by commodity production... Art provided a medium for critical thinking by upholding images of life which contradict the existent... Art anticipates the good life.”



Some criticisms of the Frankfurt School

- Frankfurt School are too limited in their approach to popular culture and mass communication, ignore agency and resistance.
- Fail to do justice to what is new and distinctive about the development of the media and mass communications and how these encourage democracy
- Fail to develop a satisfactory theory accounting for the circulation and reception of symbolic forms.
- Read off the consequences of cultural products from the products themselves.
- Their emphasis upon general features like standardization, commodification and reification fail to take into consideration the everyday practices of popular culture and media organizations.
- Still no clear evidence that the reception and consumption of the products of the culture industry impel individuals to adhere to any social order.
- Audience studies suggest that the reception and appropriation of cultural products is a complex social process which involves a dialectical relationship between agency and structure.



SC301

Class 12: Marx, Ideology and the Frankfurt School

Adorno “The Culture Industry Revisited” : pp.85-92 : Activity for Class

Reflecting on the Key Reading, consider these statements in pairs / groups. What do they mean and, using your sociological imagination, what is the validity of each statement?

- “The recognition of brand names has taken the place of choice.”
- “The culture business comes to resemble contests... and finally sport.”
- Films “knock out” their audiences
- “Sport is not play but ritual in which the subjected celebrate their subjection.”
- “Anyone who is incapable of talking in the prescribed fashion... is threatened in his very existence.”